varsha elango



PROJECTS

Is United States, Not Texas.

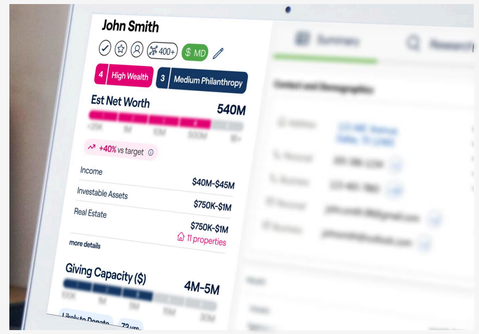
A Score To Find The Right People

Old to New

Sharing Codes

A Score To Find The Right People

Redesign the wealth and P2G score visualisation on a wealth intelligence platform.



Background: WealthEngine scores every profile on two things: how much money someone has, and how likely they are to give it away. Those two numbers are the first thing a fundraiser looks at and the filter that decides who gets contacted at all.

Problem: Two scores side by side, one legend between them. Higher was better on one, lower on the other.
Neither had a reference point. The same person can be a major prospect for a small charity and below the threshold for a national one, and the score couldn't tell you which you were looking at.
The people who used the platform most had stopped looking at it entirely.
The brief was to make the score clearer. Research showed nobody stops at the score, so I proposed the redesign should serve what happens after it.

Impact: In production. Across eight organisations, clarity moved from confusion to 4s and 5s. Trust stayed at 3–4, for reasons outside the design.



"I could have a staff member look at this and go right to where I need them to go."
President & CEO, community foundation

Users
Fundraisers, prospect researchers, gift officers, and outreach teams

Partner
WealthEngine, Altrata, London (in production)

Team
Lead Designer (me)
UI/UX Director
Project Manager
Data Architect

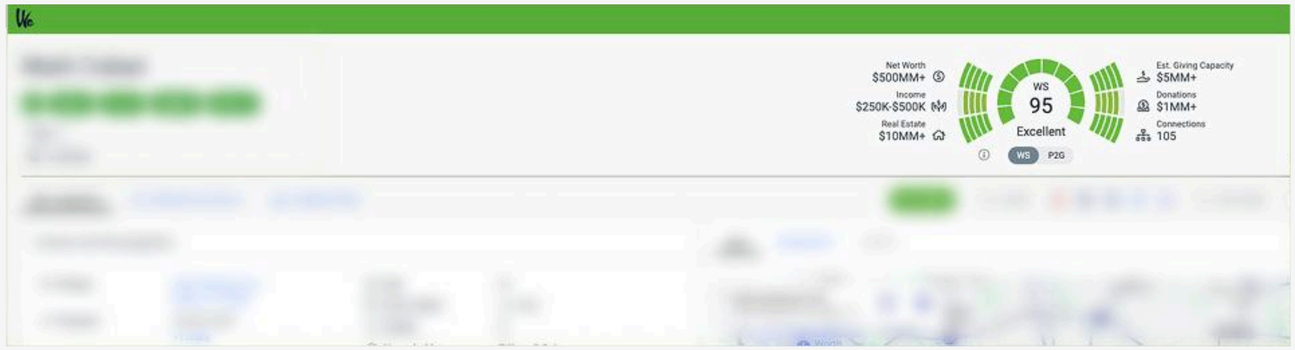
What I did
User Research
Problem Statement
Conceptualization
User testing
Dev handoff

Duration
3 Months

PROCESS

Identified problem
Design Audit & User Research

I audited WealthEngine's two proprietary scores, Wealth Score and P2G (Propensity to Give), then ran research across eight organisations, from solo fundraisers to national nonprofits.
Different verticals had different use cases, and daily users had different problems from occasional ones. The product treated them all the same.



Existing profile page with score in WE

1. Two scores, adjacent, running opposite directions.

The wealth score reads higher-is-better. P2G reads lower-is-better. They sit side by side with a single legend.

> "The wealth score and the P2G, I feel they're telling me kind of the same thing. So I'm looking at one or the other or both."
>
> Development Manager, regional arts nonprofit



A decade in fundraising, actively training her team on these scores, and she couldn't tell them apart.

Consistency and Standards (Nielsen #4)

Users should not have to wonder whether different words, situations, or actions mean the same thing.



Wealth Score



P2G Score

2. One score is always visible; the other is hidden.

Wealth Score shows by default; P2G sits behind a segmented control. Everyone sees wealth first whether they came for it or not. The supporting data is static, so nothing shows what moves either score.

> From design audit and client validation.



3. The score is skipped entirely by the users who know the product best.

Some users scrolled straight past the top of the profile to the giving capacity breakdown.

> "I don't really use the score visuals too much. I already am just looking at the top people. So then I want to know, where is their money? I can just see the numbers right here. It's 3 million, and it's all in real estate."
>
> Director of Prospect Research, national health nonprofit



score is not carried along until the end of the workflow

4. With senior staff, the score loses to raw data.

Senior staff trust what they can see over what we calculate.

> "my gift managers rely less on the P2G scores or any wealth screening scores. They would rather see real data"
>
> Development Manager, regional arts nonprofit



Gulf of Evaluation (Norman, The Design of Everyday Things)

The gap between what a system outputs and the user's ability to interpret and verify it. A score with no visible derivation leaves that gulf entirely uncrossed.

5. Unclear reasoning. The tool doesn't fully show how it derived the score.

Every session asked the same thing. Where did this come from, and how do I check it? Nobody wanted the model explained, just enough to sanity-check it.



> "in order to trust that data, you need to validate it."
>
> Director of Prospect Research, national health nonprofit

> "where does the data come from? When I use ChatGPT & often I'm like, oh, let me just click on the link that it cited"
>
> Ops Director, giving nonprofit

6. Users don't know what their own data does.

Users don't know whether their supplemental data affects the score.



> "if I put in supplemental information about a donor, I don't believe at this time that it's used in any of the wealth scores.""
>
> Development Manager, regional arts nonprofit

Visibility of System Status (Nielsen #1)

Users should know what the system is doing with their input. Contributing data and getting no signal back is the sign of system failure.

Different tangent. Flagged, solved separately.

Law of Proximity (Gestalt)

Elements placed close together are perceived as related. Grouping connections with the scores implies a relationship that doesn't exist.

7. Connections sits at score level, but isn't part of the score

Connections is useful data, but it doesn't feed either score or relate to anything shown beside it.

> From design audit and client validation.



Redefining the brief

8. Nobody stops at the score

Not one participant used it alone. Verifying, cross-referencing, annotating, exporting: that's where the time goes, and the brief treated all of it as out of scope.



> "I don't just look at Wealth Engine score. It has it be a part of the narrative, but I also compare profiles on Donor Search (competitor)"
>
> Development Manager, regional arts nonprofit
> Prospect Researcher, national advocacy organisation

> "I'll take the score information and add to my report to verify some of the information on there."
>
> Prospect researcher, religious nonprofit



That redefines the brief.

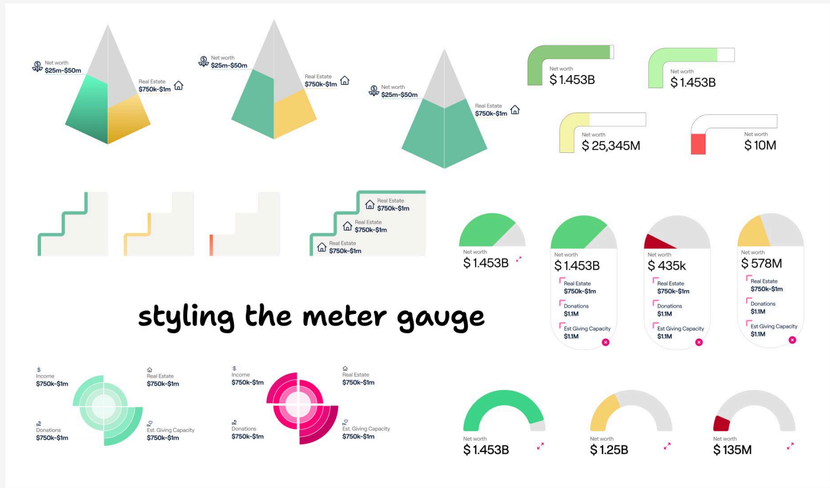
The question isn't how do we make the score more convincing. It's how do we make it support everything the user does afterwards.

Ideation

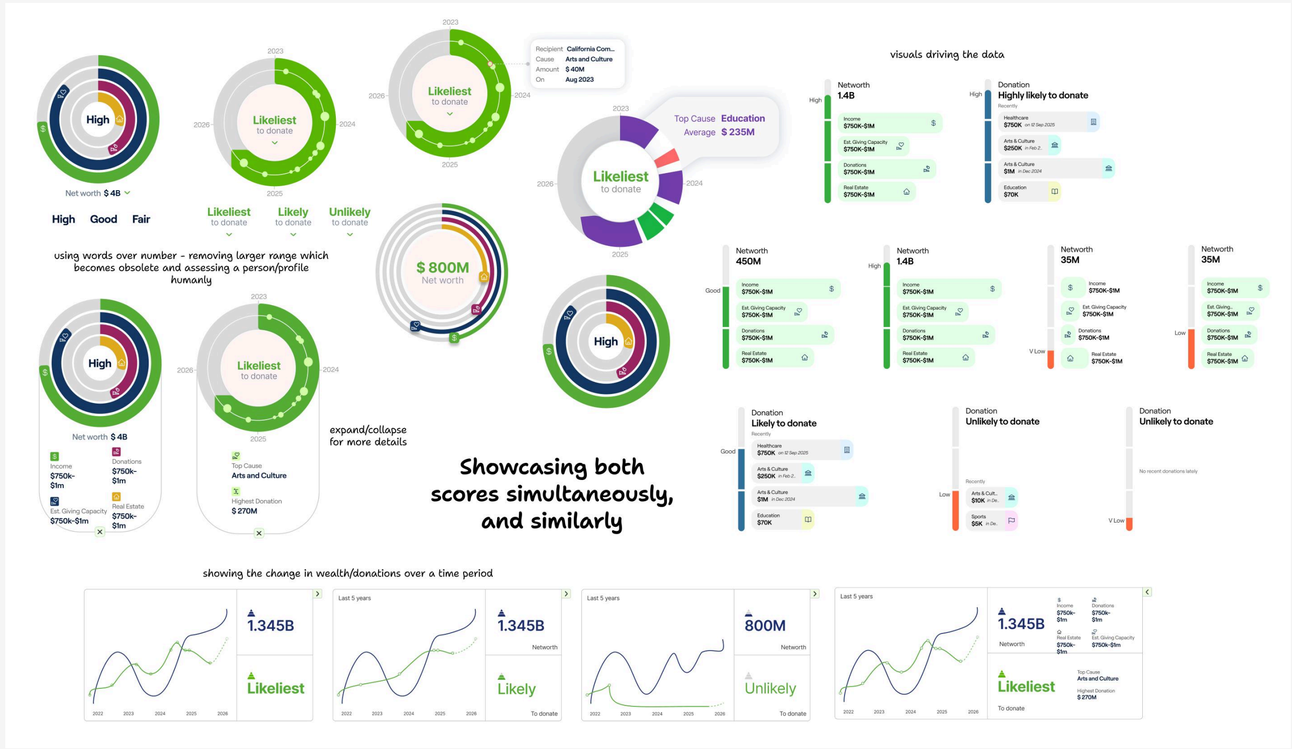
Freehand to digitising

With permission to rewrite the score logic rather than restyle it, the range of answers opened up. Five aims carried into every direction:

- **Words supporting numbers** - To explore methods of scoring and reading a score
- **Significance beyond a number** - Surface the metadata that actually moves a decision
- **Visuals reflecting the values** - Reduce the load of interpretation
- **Both scores viewable together** - Different users need different ones first
- **Visual consistency between them** - They sit adjacent, so they should read as one system



Freehand meter gauge explorations



Digitised directions, showing both scores simultaneously, and similarity

Concepts / Version One

What was taken to the clients as the first draft

There were 3 concepts, explorative but sufficient enough to consume feedback to know if we were on the right track.
A few things that stayed across the concepts were,

1. Net worth as the wealth score.

It's the most concrete value in the database. Every other data point sits in a range that supports it.

2. Words as the score.

All three scores express a likelihood, so the number does less work than the phrase. A visual cue carries the magnitude.

3. Source made explicit.

Your data, Altrata data, Altrata predictions - labelled wherever they appear, so users can see how their own uploads contribute.

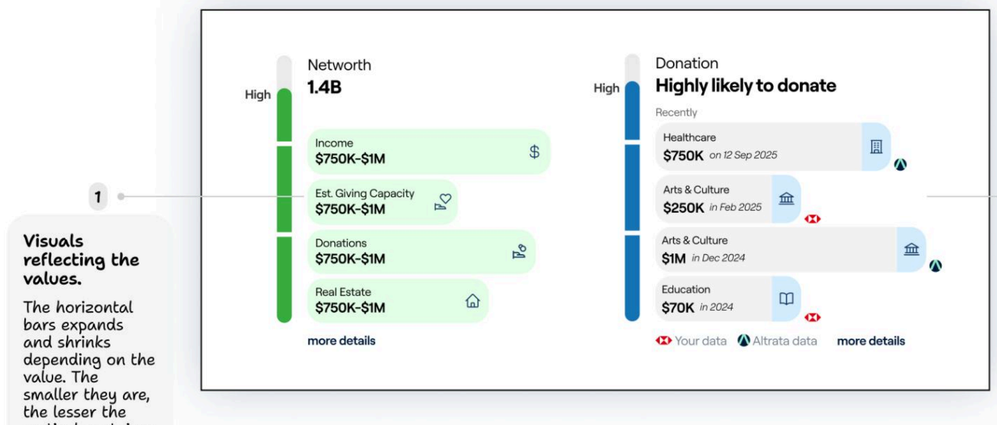
4. Expandable detail.

Every concept holds a second layer: the values behind the score, and a route to the profile.

1 Two-way bar chart

Every supporting value visible at once, sized to what it's worth.

Path
Data dense



1

Visuals reflecting the values.

The horizontal bars expands and shrinks depending on the value. The smaller they are, the lesser the vertical container fills.

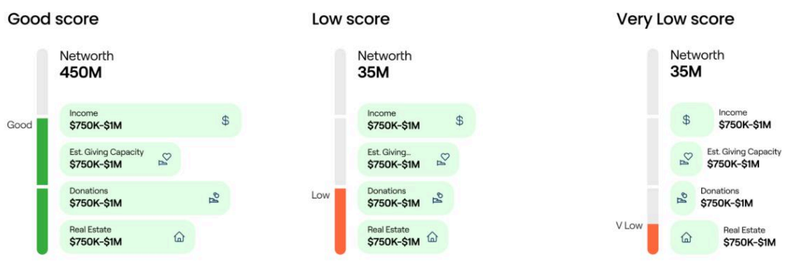
2

Relevant meta data

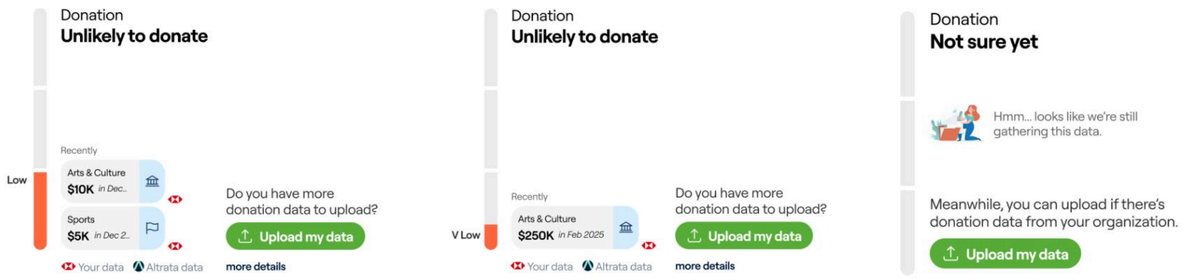
Showing the most recent donations in the database, along with the sectors and values, that directly speaks with different kinds of customers.

Read six values, decide yourself

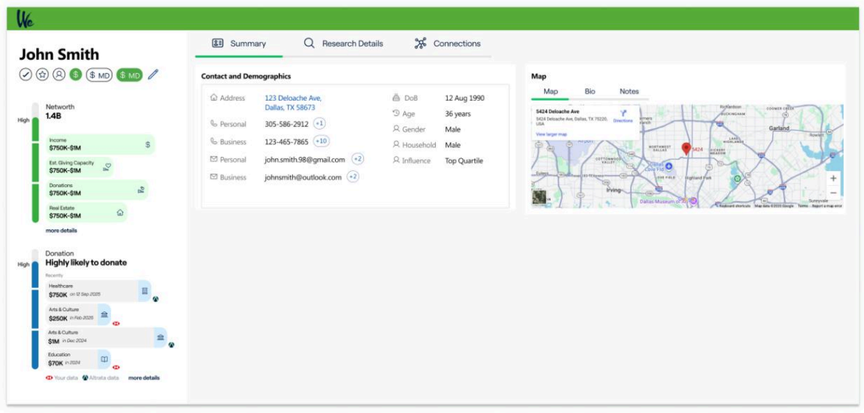
Wealth Score - Different instances



Donation Score - Lack of data availability



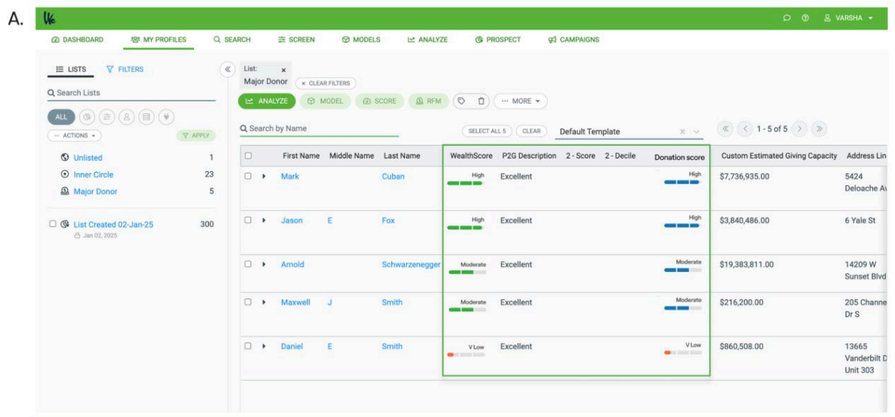
This concept demands changing the layout of the current WE profiles, as the score can stay sticky on the profile, as a point of reference while scanning the profile details



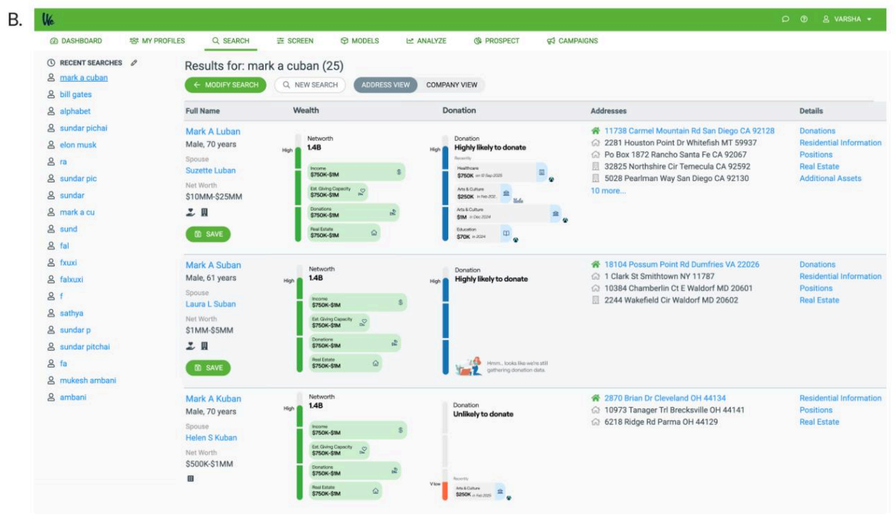
Proposal to change the base layout of the profile pages

Ways on how the score appears in search results and list views

A.



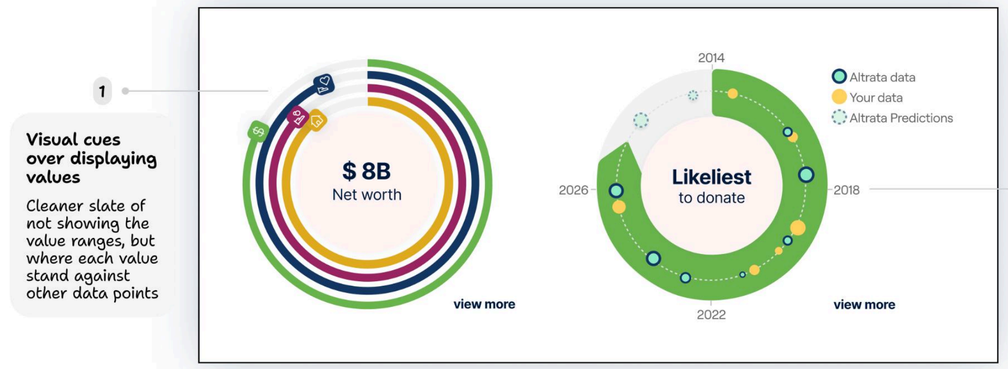
B.



2 Elevated donuts

The same data, plus when it happened. Giving as a timeline rather than a list.

Path
Data dense + Timeline



Visual cues over displaying values

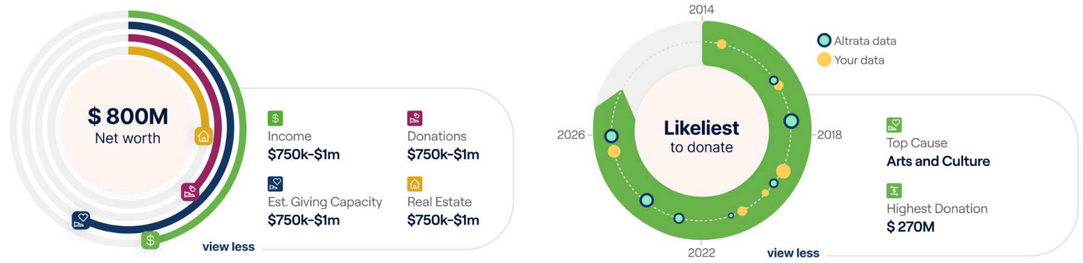
Cleaner slate of not showing the value ranges, but where each value stand against other data points

Timeline of donations made

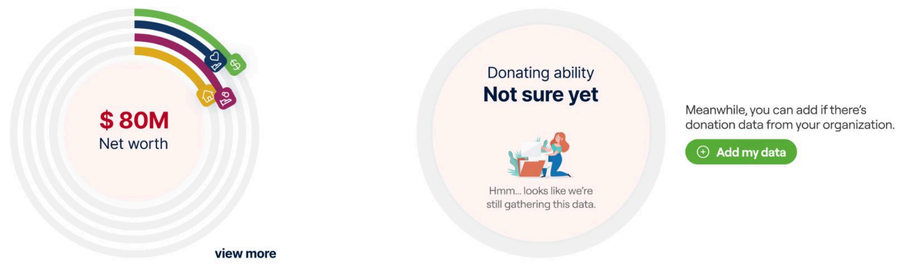
Ring that pans across a timeline set by the user, plotting donations made across the time frame. The bigger the plot, the bigger the donation amount.

Read the shape, expand for detail

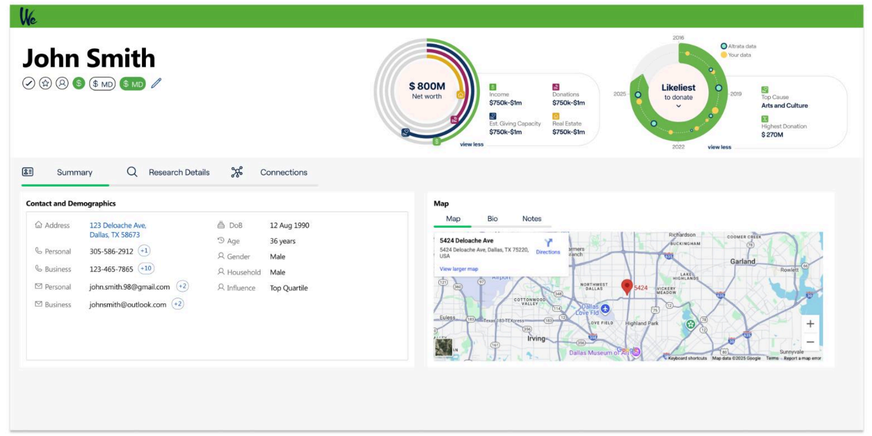
On expansion

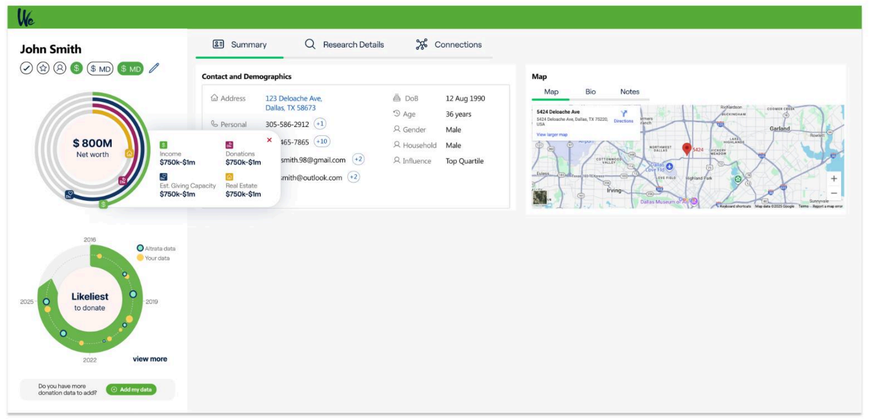


Score when there's lack of data availability



Different profile layouts to accommodate the score

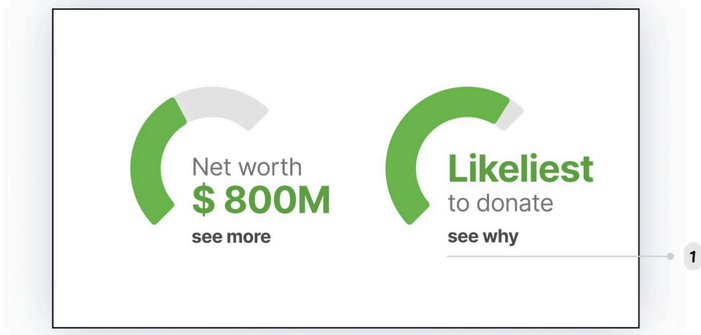




3 Rich-o-meter

What if the score is just a quick reference to indicate whether the profile is worth exploring?

Path
Quick Overview



See more, See why

On click, modal opens up to show values of all data points that the score comprises of and a quick brief on how the score is derive.

The reasoning logic sits with the data science team

Read one word, click if interested

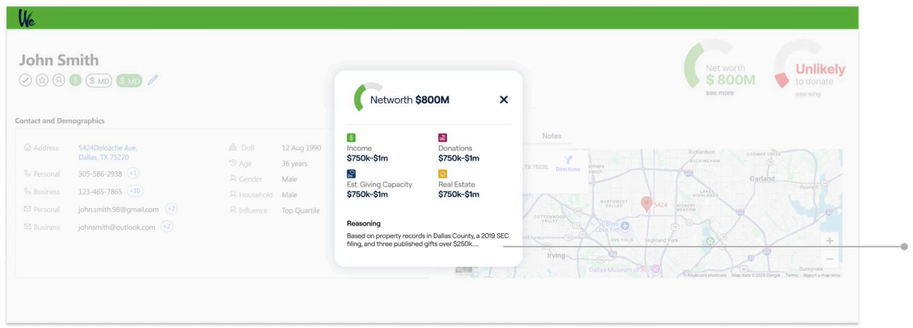
Variations of the score on different profiles



Other explorations in form

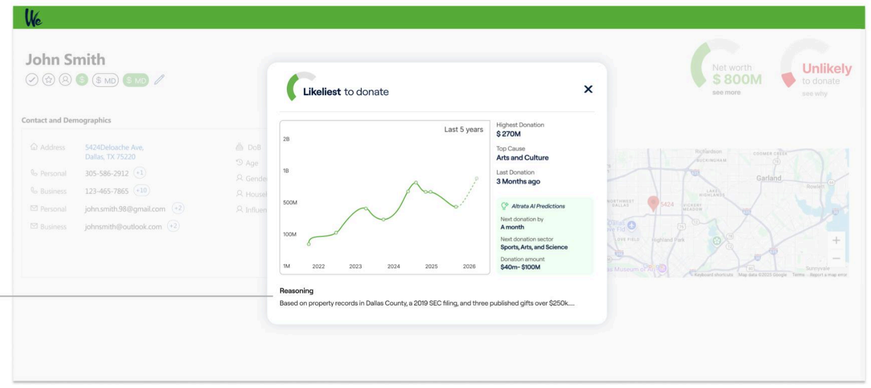


Modal to explain the reason beyond the derived score.



Indicative only - the reasoning logic sits with the data science team.

Modal to explain the reason behind the derived score and a graph plotted against all donations made and predicted donations.

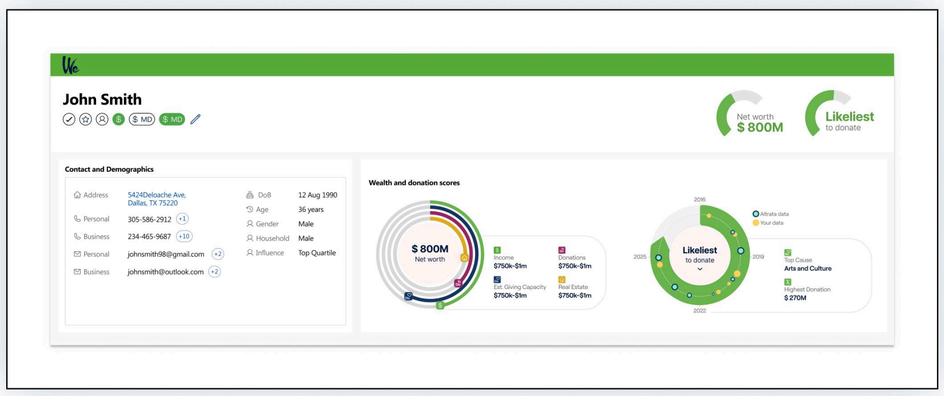


Indicative only - the reasoning logic sits with the data science team.

3.1 At-a-glance

What if Idea 3 acts as an overview, and Idea 2 follows as a deep dive

Path
Quick Overview



Enabling quick filtering from the large set of results

What came back from Round 1

Four organizations, four industries, three time zones

Concept 1 was the direction, with one objection worth listening to.

Three of four rated it 4 or 5 for clarity and usefulness. It was the easiest to read and the least decorative.

The fourth rated it 2. She's the most experienced researcher in the sample, and when she shared her screen she scrolled straight past the score.

Participant	Concept 1 Rating (Clarity, Usefulness, Trust)
Prospect Researcher	5 / 5 / 4
Ops Director	4 / 4 / 4 wealth, 3 donation
Donor Researcher	4 / 4 / 4
Director of Prospect Research	2 / 2 / 2

"We need the Honda Civic, not the Corvette. Something reliable that I can count on, is predictable, is easy to use. Anyone can drive it."

She wasn't rejecting the concept. She was saying the score wasn't where her decision happened.

Tesler's Law

Complexity the product refuses to handle gets exported to the user's spreadsheet.

1. No anchors or user-defined thresholds.

The score is calibrated to Altrata's whole population. But nobody asks "is this person wealthy?" They ask "is this person right for us?" All three concepts made the number clearer. None made it relative.

"They might have a lower net worth than the typical, but if he's at the top of my capacity, that's what matters to me."

Ops Director, giving nonprofit

"Being able to put in what the organisation's thresholds are would be helpful with reporting, and consistency with how each organisation does their prospecting."

Salesforce administrator, civil rights nonprofit

2. All relevant meta data worth surfacing at the score level

Recency is shown; significance isn't. Top causes are valuable.

"you pull in the most recent 5 gifts of 10,000, but you missed that the one from two years ago that was a $1,000,000 gift... I would just hate to miss someone's big gift because it wasn't the most recent."

Ops Director, giving nonprofit

Property count matters along with real estate value

"Is that one piece or many pieces of real estate? That's the big deal. If they had five houses that equal 750,000 to a million, those are a lot of maybe rentals or something."

Prospect researcher, religious nonprofit

3. Vertical stacking defeats comparison in lists

In lists they want a simple, sortable value they can compare across rows at a glance, not the full summary that belongs on the profile.

"What's nice about the one on the left is I can compare them against each other. It's really hard to compare vertically."

Ops Director, giving nonprofit

4. Number still matters alongside passive words

"Likely is helpful, but seeing the number would be a really strong indicator. Say 90 and higher is our goal. They're in 90, cool, we keep going. But if they're in the 80 to 90, then clicking in and seeing why might be good."

Salesforce administrator, civil rights nonprofit

5. The score leaves the product as an image

The score has to survive being cropped out and dropped into a document. No surrounding UI, no hover, no explanation. That rules out anything interaction-dependent, and it's why concept 2 scored lowest.

"I take the wealth score and add it to my shortlisted donor profiles. It's helpful for our external consultant or executive director, because they don't have access to Wealth Engine."

Salesforce administrator, civil rights nonprofit

6. Trust wasn't tracking the design.

Clarity and usefulness moved with each concept. Trust didn't, and the reasons were never about what they were looking at. They were about past experience and the data itself.

"To me it's more the quality of data that can be improved, versus the visual representation."

Director of Prospect Research, national health nonprofit

"Most of the information is matching up with what I'm finding online. So I can verify what I'm getting from WE."

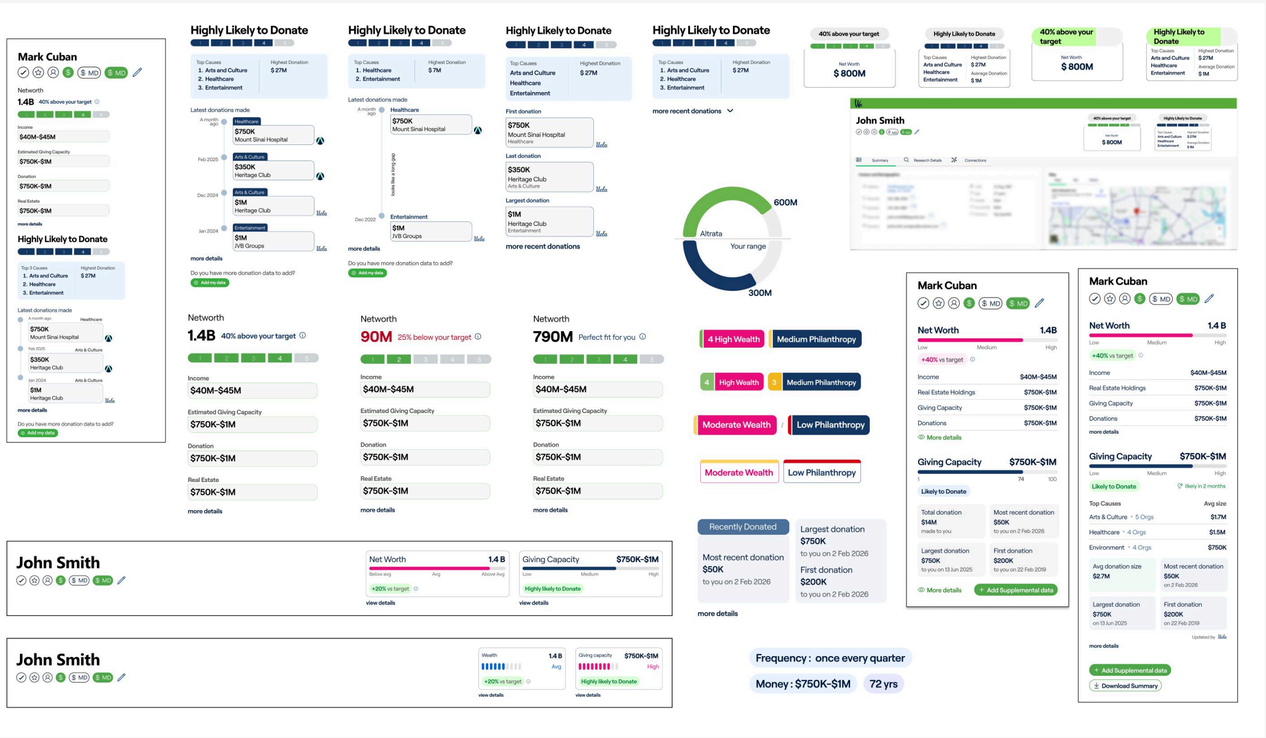
Salesforce admin, Donor researcher, Equal Rights Advocates

What I took from it.

Trust is earned outside the product, by cross-checking. A redesign can't move that. So the reasoning layer isn't there to convince anyone, it's there to shorten the checking they'll do anyway.

Ideation, again

Shaped by round 1



Version Two

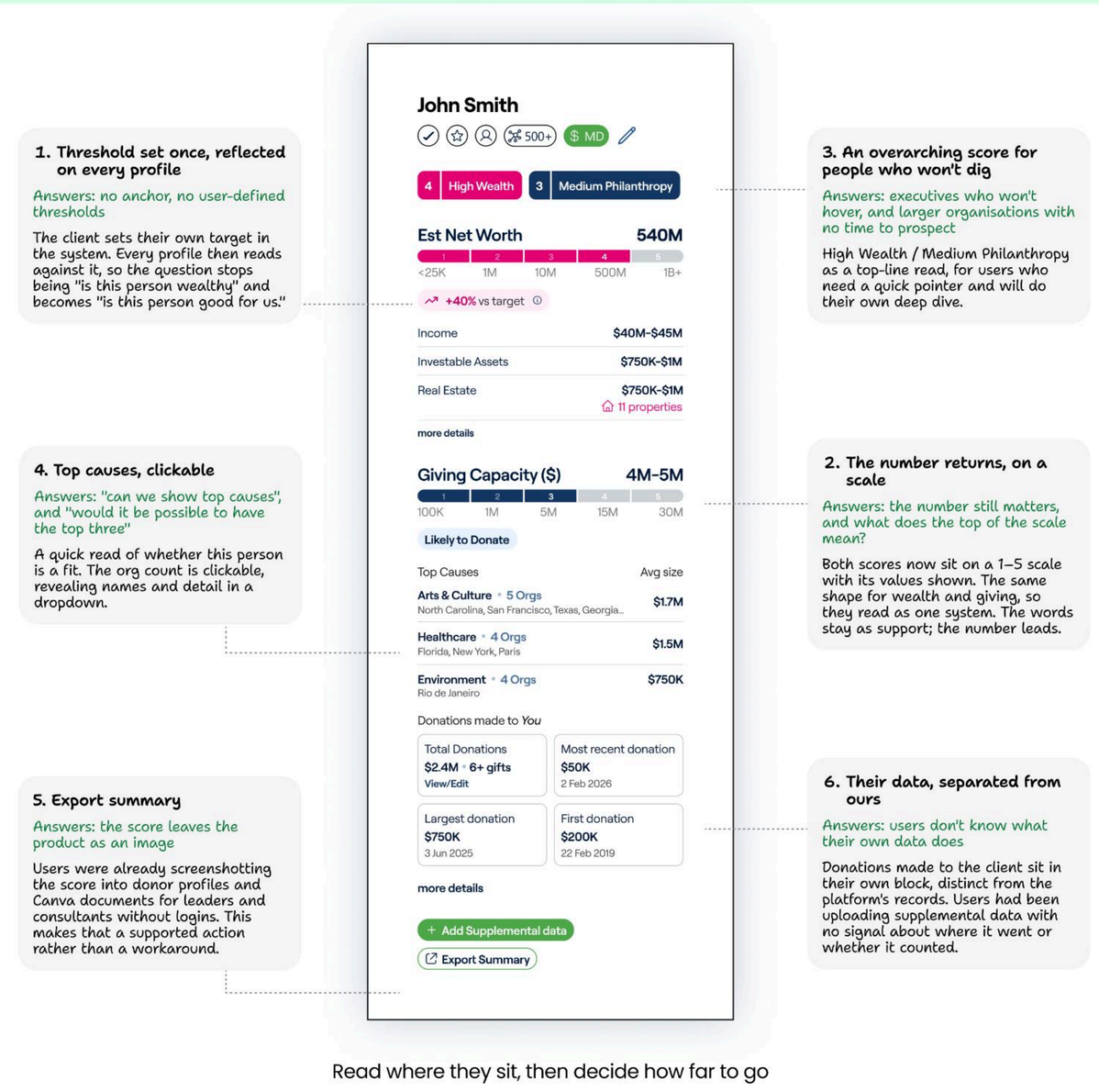
Evolution of Concept 1

Seven of the eight round 1 findings are answered here. The eighth, planned giving, is a data problem rather than a design one, and sits with another team. Design has provided a placeholder.

Score as a profile summary

Every value anchored to a scale, and to the client's own target

Path
Score + Meta data



1. Threshold set once, reflected on every profile

Answers: no anchor, no user-defined thresholds

The client sets their own target in the system. Every profile then reads against it, so the question stops being "is this person wealthy" and becomes "is this person good for us."

3. An overarching score for people who won't dig

Answers: executives who won't hover, and larger organisations with no time to prospect

High Wealth / Medium Philanthropy as a top-line read, for users who need a quick pointer and will do their own deep dive.

4. Top causes, clickable

Answers: "can we show top causes", and "would it be possible to have the top three"

A quick read of whether this person is a fit. The org count is clickable, revealing names and detail in a dropdown.

2. The number returns, on a scale

Answers: the number still matters, and what does the top of the scale mean?

Both scores now sit on a 1–5 scale with its values shown. The same shape for wealth and giving, so they read as one system. The words stay as support; the number leads.

5. Export summary

Answers: the score leaves the product as an image

Users were already screenshotting the score into donor profiles and Canva documents for leaders and consultants without logins. This makes that a supported action rather than a workaround.

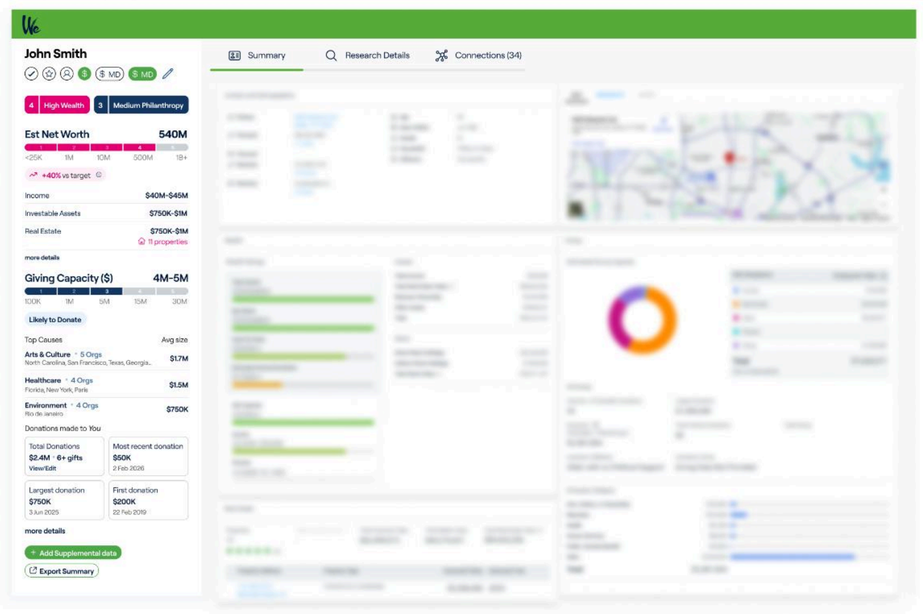
6. Their data, separated from ours

Answers: users don't know what their own data does

Donations made to the client sit in their own block, distinct from the platform's records. Users had been uploading supplemental data with no signal about where it went or whether it counted.

Read where they sit, then decide how far to go

On profile page

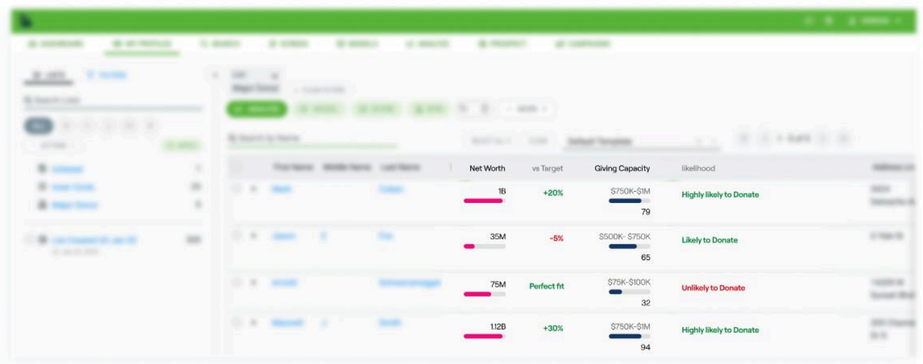


7. A sticky summary panel

Answers: the score disappears once the deep dive starts

The summary stays fixed while the profile scrolls. The score stops being a value you pass on the way in, and becomes a reference you can check against while reading the detail.

In list or search result pages

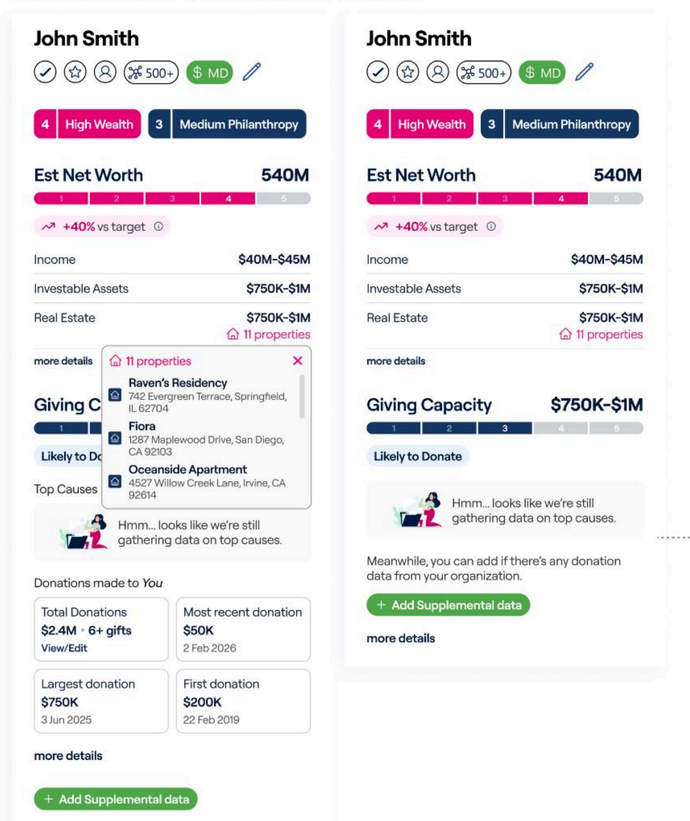


8. One sortable value per row

Answers: vertical stacking defeats comparison in lists

In lists the score collapses to one value plus its distance from target, comparable straight down a column. The full summary stays on the profile, where the user has already committed to looking.

When there is lack of donation data available



9. Empty states that ask for something

Answers: donation coverage is thin, and users know it

Where data is missing the profile says so and offers the one action that fixes it. Carried forward from version 1, the part nobody objected to.

What came back from Round 2

Four organizations, four industries, three time zones

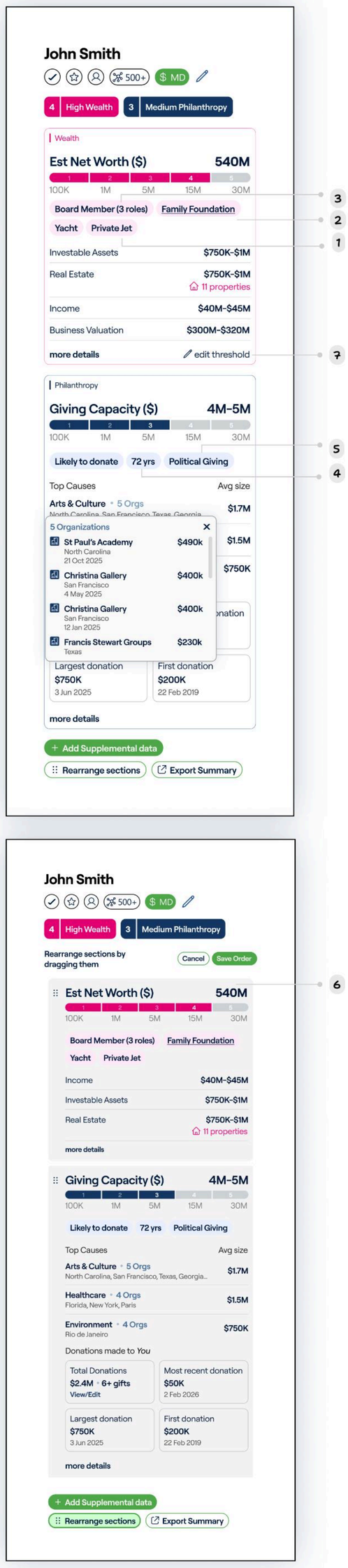
Every participant rated it 4 or 5 for clarity. The layout worked, the scale gave people something to read against, and nobody had to be talked through it.

What they added shaped the final design. Seven things came out of these sessions, and one architectural limit changed how the strongest of them shipped.

Participant	Evolved Concept 1 Rating (Clarity, Usefulness, Trust)
Prospect Researcher	4 / 4 / 3
Development Director	5 / 4 / 3
Development Manager	5 / 5 / 3-4
President & CEO	5 / 5 / 3-4

The final design

Seven changes from round 2, and one architectural limitation



1. Assets flagged alongside net worth

Answers: capacity that hasn't converted into giving

Prospect Researcher, national advocacy organisation

"Jet planes, yachts, telling you this person has the money to be philanthropic. They're just not there yet."

President & CEO, community foundation

"More than one home? An airplane? Boats? It shows appreciated assets."

Two uses for the same data. One finds capacity ahead of any giving history. The other identifies appreciated assets, which is how most community foundation gifts are actually made.

2. Family foundations and donor-advised funds

Answers: a competitive signal, not just a data point

President & CEO, community foundation

"Their propensity to have a donor advised fund. If someone already has a DAF, I approach that person differently."

His competition is the banks running their own DAF products. Knowing a prospect already has one changes the conversation entirely. Even flagging that a gift went to a foundation, without naming which, would be useful.

3. Board and community involvement

Answers: knowing who not to approach

Development Manager, regional arts nonprofit

"Can't go after them, they're a board of trustees at Mote Marine. It's less career data, more community involvement."

A disqualifier rather than a prospecting signal. It saves effort rather than generating leads, which is why nobody asks for it directly.

4. Age at score level

Answers: age is a threshold, not a trend

Development Manager, regional arts nonprofit

"I'm wanting people who have at least hit that threshold, 73 and a half, in terms of required minimum distributions."

At 73, US retirees must draw down retirement accounts, and charitable distributions are a common way to handle the tax. Age doesn't correlate with generosity, it marks the point where giving becomes financially advantageous. Her average donor is 80.

5. Political giving, surfaced at the top

Answers: it's one of the few kinds of giving you can actually see

Prospect Researcher, national advocacy organisation

"A lot of people's early philanthropy is political giving. It tells you a lot about the kind of giver someone is."

Most charitable giving is private. Political donations are declared by law, so they're visible when nothing else is, and people often give politically before they give philanthropically.

6. A rearrangeable score panel

Answers: different verticals read the panel in different orders

Fundraisers open with philanthropic history, assessing willingness. Foundations and financial services open with net worth, assessing capacity. Rather than picking a default someone has to work around, the order is set at client level.

7. Configurable scale values

Answers: the anchor, within what the architecture could carry

The anchor was round 1's strongest finding, but comparing every profile against a client-set target needed infrastructure we didn't have in the timeframe. We pushed it to a later release with architecture and development.

What shipped instead: configurable scale bands, so a client defines what each band means for their portfolio and scores read against their population rather than the platform's.

Clarity moved. Trust didn't.

The Finding

Trust sat at 3–4 across every participant, both rounds, and every concept. Almost none of the reasons were about the design.

"No matter how amazing it looks, I'm always going to be 3 to 4 on trust. Just because of my own experiences with such products"

Development Manager, regional arts nonprofit

"I would be somewhere between a three and a four, because I have found gaps in the data."

President & CEO, community foundation

What that told me

The Reflection

Trust is bounded by data quality and professional scepticism. Design can't manufacture it, but it can shorten the checking people do anyway. So showing where the number came from became a requirement, and the redesign supports verification rather than replacing it.

Now in production.

The Outcome

Product, engineering, architecture, commercial and customer success were all walked through the research and bought into the direction. The design is in production, with the full anchor scoped for a later release.